



Handout 5.15: Upcycle Design Brief and Idea Menu

Name: _____ Date: _____ Station: _____

Word bank: cut, sew, fold, stitch, pocket, bag Spanish: cortar, coser, doblar, puntada, bolsillo, bolsa

Page 1. The idea menu

First, three definitions

Word	What it means	My clothing example
Recycle	Breaking a thing down to its raw material and making something new out of the material	
Upcycle	Keeping the material and turning it into something worth more or just as useful	
Repurpose	Same material, same shape, new job	

This project skips the _____ card from the journey set in Lesson 5.14.

The four constraints

Every project. No exceptions.

1. It must start from a **used textile**. Not new fabric off a roll.
2. It must be **finished in two build days** (Lesson 5.17, two periods of 40 minutes).
3. It must use **at least two of the taught joins (hand stitches or a machine seam)**: running stitch, backstitch, whipstitch, sewing on a button.
4. It must be **something somebody would actually use**, and you have to name who.

The ten paths

The difficulty mark is how hard the construction is. It is not how good a grade it can earn. An Easy path built well scores higher than a Harder path built badly.

#	Path	Starts from	Becomes	Stitches you will need	Difficulty	Does the scrap bin have it?
1	T-shirt tote bag, no sewing on the body	A t-shirt	A bag for groceries, books, or gym clothes	Whipstitch the handles to reinforce them	Easy	
2	T-shirt headband	A t-shirt sleeve or a strip of the body	A headband or hair tie	Whipstitch the ends into a loop, running stitch to	Easy	

				gather		
3	Sweater sleeve phone sleeve	One sleeve of a sweater or sweatshirt	A padded sleeve for a phone, glasses, or a calculator	Whipstitch the cut end closed, backstitch a reinforcement	Easy	
4	Pillowcase drawstring bag	A pillowcase	A drawstring bag for shoes, laundry, or supplies	Running stitch for the drawstring channel, backstitch the side seam	Easy	
5	Patchwork square	Four or more fabric scraps	A mat, a potholder-style square, or a wall square	Backstitch to join the pieces, whipstitch the outer edge	Easy	
6	Jeans-leg pencil case	One leg of a pair of jeans	A pencil case, tool roll, or brush case	Backstitch the bottom, whipstitch the edges, a button for the flap	Medium	
7	Shirt pillow cover	A button-front shirt	A pillow cover that uses the button placket as the opening	Backstitch three sides, whipstitch raw edges	Medium	
8	Towel produce bag	A hand towel or a cut piece of a bath towel	A washable bag for fruit and vegetables	Backstitch two sides, running stitch the top channel	Medium	

9	Sock rice hand warmer	A clean sock with no holes	A hand warmer you heat at home	Running stitch to close, whipstitch the same seam a second time	Medium	
10	Sweatshirt cuff wristlet	The cuff of a sweatshirt	A wristlet or key pouch	Whipstitch one edge closed, backstitch a small inside pocket	Medium	

Design your own. Bring me the brief with a sketch and measurements. If it fits the four constraints, it is approved.

Rice hand warmer rules. Uncooked rice only. Nothing scented. It is never heated at school. Heating happens at home with an adult, 30 seconds maximum, and your display card must say so. If rice is a problem for you or anybody at home, use dried beans or flax seed.

Screen your three ideas

My idea	Constraint 1: used textile?	Constraint 2: two build days?	Constraint 3: two taught stitches?	Constraint 4: a real user?	Keep or cross out

If you crossed one out, write which constraint it failed: _____

Page 2. The design brief

1. What I start with

What it is: _____

Its size in inches: _____ inches by _____ inches

Fiber, if the label can be read: _____ (write “no label” if there is none)

Its condition (holes, stains, wear, pilling, missing parts): _____

Where it came from: ☐ the room’s scrap bin ☐ the donation drive ☐ home, with a signed note

Does it stretch when you pull it sideways? ☐ yes, it is a knit ☐ no, it is a woven ☐ it is felt

2. What it becomes

The finished item: _____

Its finished size: _____ inches by _____ inches

3. Who will use it, and for what

The person: _____ (a name, not “anyone”)

What they will use it for: _____

4. My two stitches (at least two of the four)

Stitch 1: _____ and where on the item: _____

Stitch 2: _____ and where on the item: _____

5. My tools

☐ hand needle ☐ thread (color: _____) ☐ pins or clips ☐ fabric shears ☐ measuring tape ☐ chalk or marker ☐ thimble ☐ needle threader ☐ button ☐ cord or drawstring ☐ other:

6. Three steps, in order

Step 1: _____

Step 2: _____

Step 3: _____

7. The one thing most likely to go wrong

8. My reduced-scope version (write this now, before you need it)



If I run out of time, my item becomes: _____

9. Closing line

My item starts as _____ and becomes _____ for
_____.

Grade 8 stretch lines (optional)

The one measurement that ruins this if I get it wrong: _____

What it would cost to buy this new: \$_____. What it cost me to make: \$_____. The
difference: \$_____

Page 3. The picture plan template (a full-credit way to do the brief)

Draw instead of writing. Fill every number blank. This is scored the same as the written brief.

BOX 1: Draw what you start with. Write its size in inches on two sides of your drawing.

[Draw here. Label the length and the width.]

Size: _____ in by _____ in

BOX 2: Draw what it becomes. Write the finished size on two sides.

[Draw here. Label the length and the width.]

Size: _____ in by _____ in

BOX 3: Draw the person who will use it, and draw the thing they will put in it or the way they will wear it.

[Draw here.]

Their name: _____

BOX 4: Draw your two stitches on the item. Use a solid line for the cut, a dashed line for the fold, and a dotted line for the stitching. Label which stitch goes where.

[Draw here.]

Stitch 1: _____ Stitch 2: _____

BOX 5: Circle the tools you need.

needle / thread / pins / clips / shears / tape measure / chalk / thimble / threader /
button / cord

BOX 6: Number your three steps by drawing them, 1, 2, 3.

[Draw three small boxes here.]

BOX 7: Circle the part you are worried about on your BOX 2 drawing, and put a star on it.

BOX 8: Draw the smaller version, if you run out of time.

[Draw here.]

Page 4. Permission note (take home tonight)

Cut along the line and bring the bottom half back signed.

Family and Consumer Sciences, Unit 5: the Upcycle Challenge

Dear family,

For the next six class days my students are turning a used piece of cloth into something useful, by hand, with a needle and thread. No sewing machine is needed; every path can be built by hand. We cover needle and pin safety every day, we count every needle and pin out at the start of the period and back in at the end, and nobody leaves the room until the counts match.

Your student does not need to bring anything from home. Our classroom has a bin of donated and scrap fabric, and every student can take what they need from it. That is the normal way to do this project and it earns full credit.

If your student would rather use something of their own, it has to be something you are willing to have cut up and sewn, because it will not go back to being what it was. Please sign below only if that is the case. Nothing valuable, nothing borrowed, and nothing that belongs to somebody else.

If you have clean, used textiles you would like to donate to the class bin (t-shirts, towels, pillowcases, jeans, sweaters with holes, sheets, fabric scraps), we will take them and everyone will use them. Donating is not required and is not tracked.

Thank you,

Permission to use an item from home

Student name: _____

The item my student is bringing: _____

I understand this item will be cut and sewn and will not go back to what it was. I am fine with that.

Signature of the owner or an adult in the home: _____

Date: _____ Phone or email, if you want a copy of the finished item's photo:
